

6



Fast Fashion



QUIZ

HOW GREEN ARE YOU?



1. Tick the letter (a, b, c) you prefer. It is a kind of survey so there is no correct answer. Announce the results in class, and talk about them focusing on questions 3, 4 and 5. You will know more about your choices after the end of the unit.

◆ You are walking back home drinking water. What do you do with the plastic bottle when you have finished?

- a. You just get rid of it and throw it anywhere.
- b. You carry it until you find a bin to put it in.
- c. You carry it until you find the proper bin to put it in.

◆ Do you recycle materials such as paper, glass, tins etc?

- a. No
- b. Yes
- c. Sometimes

◆ Think about your closet. How many T-shirts can you count?

- a. 2-5
- b. 6-10
- c. more than 11

◆ What is your main concern when you buy clothes?

- a. The price.
- b. Whether they carry a Fair Trade label.
- c. The material they are made of.

◆ What is your most favourite fabric to wear?

- a. Cotton/leather.
- b. Polyester/synthetics.
- c. Bamboo/hemp.

2. *True* or *False*?



What do you think about the following statements? Mark them as true or false. Don't check your answers until after you have finished the reading tasks. You will come back then to see whether you were right or wrong.

		True	False
1.	When we say "fast fashion" we mean experienced workers who work fast.		
2.	Organic cotton is no doubt the friendliest to the environment.		
3.	Before we rush to buy new clothes during the January sales, we should think about the impact of our clothes on the environment.		
4.	Textile dyeing is one of the main large polluters of clean water globally.		
5.	Polyester microfibres may end up being eaten by human beings.		
6.	The expansion of fast fashion shops is a proof that fast fashion has a serious impact on us all globally.		
7.	In Britain, most of the people recycle clothes.		
8.	Busy lifestyles make us more time-poor than previous generations, but with many sewing and mending skills.		
9.	It is easy to choose an eco-friendly fabric, since nowadays everything is labelled.		
10.	Transport does not affect the environment at all.		

3. Fill in the 1st and the 2nd columns of the following KWL chart. Are your clothes friendly to the environment? What do you know about the issue and what do you want to know about it? You will come back to fill in the last column after having worked on the issue.

KWL Chart

The environmental impact of my closet

What I know	What I want to know	What I have learned

4. ♦ Form groups of four. This is your “jigsaw group”.

- ♦ In your group decide which part of the text below you will read (1-2-3-4) - let's call them the “orange part”, the “blue part”, the “red part” and the “green part”. Each one of you reads individually a different part, taking notes or underlining key-points.
- ♦ Then, move to another group formed according to the part you have read (1-2-3-4). Now, there is an “orange group”, a “blue group”, a “red group” and a “green group”. This is your “expert group”!
- ♦ In your “expert group”, discuss about your part, trying to reach a common understanding of its idea and meaning. Talk about the words you don't understand (you can look them up in the dictionary).
- ♦ Finally, go back to your first group (“jigsaw group”). Now each one in the group tries to explain everything he/she has learned about his/her part to the rest of the group. Talk about your parts, in turns. The others should be taking notes and they can ask you questions. Be prepared to answer!



1. It's tough to love our clothes and keep wearing them for longer when we are faced with a tempting array of newness on offer in the shops.

But before you head out into the January sales for those irresistible deals, spare a thought for the impact of fast fashion on the environment.

Fast fashion focuses on speed and low costs in order to deliver frequent new collections inspired by catwalk looks or celebrity styles. But it is particularly bad for the environment, as pressure to reduce cost and the time it takes to get a product from design to shop floor means that environmental corners are more likely to be cut. Criticisms of fast fashion include its negative environmental impact, water pollution, the use of toxic chemicals and increasing levels of textile waste.



jigsaw puzzle

Vibrant colours, prints and fabric finishes are appealing features of fashion garments, but many of these are achieved with toxic chemicals. Textile dyeing is the second largest polluter of clean water globally, after agriculture.

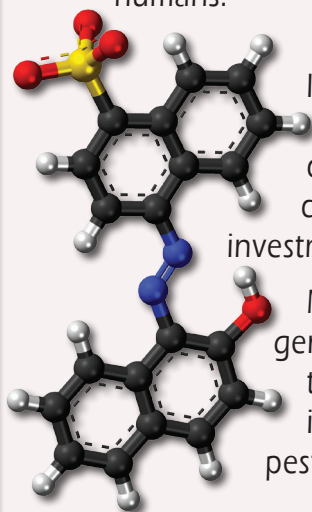


Greenpeace's recent Detox campaign has been instrumental in pressuring fashion brands to take action to remove toxic chemicals from their supply chains, after it tested a number of brands' products and confirmed the presence of hazardous chemicals. Many of these are banned or strictly regulated in various countries because they are toxic, bio-accumulative (meaning the substance builds up in an organism faster than the organism can excrete or metabolise it), disruptive to hormones and carcinogenic.



2. Polyester is the most popular fabric used for fashion. But when polyester garments are washed in domestic washing machines, they shed microfibres that add to the increasing levels of plastic in our oceans.

These microfibres are minute and can easily pass through sewage and wastewater treatment plants into our waterways, but because they do not biodegrade, they represent a serious threat to aquatic life. Small creatures such as plankton eat the microfibres, which then make their way up the food chain to fish and shellfish eaten by humans.



Cotton growing requires high levels of water and pesticides to prevent crop failure, which can be problematic in developing countries that may lack sufficient investment and be at risk of drought.

Most cotton grown worldwide is genetically modified to be resistant to the bollworm pest, thereby improving yield and reducing pesticide use. But this can also lead

to problems further down the line, such as the emergence of "superweeds" which are resistant to standard pesticides. They often need to be treated with more toxic pesticides that are harmful to livestock and humans.

The devastating impact of toxic chemical use in agriculture, for growing cotton, was shown in a documentary called *The True Cost*, including the death of a US cotton farmer from a brain tumour, and serious birth defects in Indian cotton farmers' children.

There is growing interest in organic cotton, with famous brands featuring among the world's top users of organic cotton by volume in 2016. But overall use of organic cotton represents less than 1 per cent of the world's total annual cotton crop.

3. Textile waste is an unintended consequence of fast fashion, as more people buy more clothes and don't keep them as long as they used to. The international expansion of fast fashion retailers exacerbates the problem on a global scale. Wardrobes in developed nations are saturated, so in order to sell more products, retailers must tempt shoppers with constant newness and convince them the items they already have are no longer fashionable.



Increasing disposable income levels over recent generations means there is less need to “make do and mend”, as it’s often cheaper and more convenient to buy new than have an item repaired. Busy lifestyles make many people more time-poor than previous generations, and with the loss of sewing and mending skills over time, there is less impetus to repair our garments. The rise of supermarket fashion that can be purchased alongside the weekly shop and the regular occurrence of seasonal sales make clothing seem “disposable” in a way it didn’t used to be.

There is interest in moving towards a more circular model of textile production which reuses materials wherever possible, yet current recycling rates for textiles are very low. Despite a long-established national network of charity shops and increasing numbers of in-store recycling points in UK high-street stores, three-quarters of Britons throw away unwanted clothing, rather than donating or recycling it.



4. So, can consumers reduce the environmental cost of fast fashion when out shopping? Choosing an eco-friendly fabric is complex

as there are pros and cons to all fibre types. Garments which are labelled as being made from natural fibres are not necessarily better than synthetic, as fibre choice is only one part of a complex picture. Fibres still have to be spun, knitted or woven, dyed, finished, sewn and transported – all of which have different environmental impacts.

For example, choosing organic fabrics is better than choosing non-organic fabrics in terms of the chemicals used to grow the fibres, but organic cotton still requires high amounts of water and the impact of dyeing is higher than the impact of dyeing polyester.



Recycled content is often best of all, as it reduces the pressure on virgin resources and tackles the growing problem of waste management. For example, Patagonia was the first outdoor clothing brand to make polyester fleece out of plastic bottles. In 2017, it decided to rationalise its T-shirt ranges and from spring 2018, will offer only two fabric options of either 100 per cent organic cotton or a blend of recycled cotton and recycled polyester, recognising that even organic cotton has a negative environmental impact.

The Love Your Clothes initiative from the charity Wrap gives information for consumers on each stage of the purchase process, from buying smarter, to caring for and repairing items, to upcycling or customisation and finally responsible disposal. Ultimately, the best thing we can do is to keep our clothing in use for longer – and buy less new stuff.



<http://www.independent.co.uk/life-style/fashion/environment-costs-fast-fashion-pollution-waste-sustainability-a8139386.html>

5. Match each part of the article to a heading.

PART	HEADING
	Hunger for newness
	Fast fashion: a killer
	What shoppers can do
	Synthetic polymer and natural fibres

6. True or False?



		True	False
1.	When we say "fast fashion" we mean experienced workers who work fast.		
2.	Organic cotton is no doubt the friendliest to the environment.		
3.	Before we rush to buy new clothes during the January sales we should think about the impact of fast fashion on the environment.		
4.	Textile dyeing is one of the main large polluters of clean water globally.		
5.	Polyester microfibres may end up being eaten by human beings.		
6.	The expansion of fast fashion retailers is a proof that fast fashion has a serious impact on us all globally.		
7.	In Britain, most of the people recycle clothes.		
8.	Busy lifestyles make us more time-poor than previous generations, but with many sewing and mending skills.		
9.	It is easy to choose an eco-friendly fabric, since nowadays everything is labelled.		
10.	Transport does not affect the environment at all.		

Now go back to the first three activities to check your answers. Were you right or wrong?



7. Fill in the blanks with the words given in the box, according to their meaning as they appear in the parts of the article.

biodegrade, array, recycling, customisation, saturated, woven, aquatic, spun, organic, yield, rationalise, garment, dye, vibrant, exacerbate, excrete, fabric, textile, pesticides, disposable

- | | | |
|-----|--|-------|
| 1. | an impressive display or range of a particular type of thing | |
| 2. | bright and striking | |
| 3. | separate and expel as waste | |
| 4. | a type of cloth or woven fabric | |
| 5. | cloth | |
| 6. | change the colour of your hair or clothes | |
| 7. | be decomposed by bacteria or other living organisms | |
| 8. | growing or living in or near water | |
| 9. | substances used for destroying insects or other organisms harmful to cultivated plants or to animals | |
| 10. | an amount produced of an agricultural or industrial product | |
| 11. | produced without the use of artificial chemicals | |
| 12. | makes (a problem, bad situation, or negative feeling) worse | |
| 13. | supplied beyond the point at which the demand for a product is satisfied | |
| 14. | an item of clothing | |
| 15. | collecting used material and making it ready for use again | |
| 16. | expendable, intended to be thrown away after use | |
| 17. | turned and twisted into yarn | |
| 18. | try to explain or justify (behaviour or an attitude) with logical reasons | |
| 19. | a modification made so that something suits | |
| 20. | formed (fabric or a fabric item) by interlacing long threads | |

8. Fill in the chart using the words with prefixes found in the article.
Think of your own ones to fill in the cells that are left blank.

Prefix Chart

PREFIX	MEANING	WORD
anti	against	
bi	two	
com/con	with	
de	away	
dis	apart/no	
em/en	in/into	
ex	out/away from	
fore/pre	before	
in/im	in/into	
in/im/ir/il	not	
inter	between/among	
mid	middle of	
mis	badly/wrongly	
non	no/not/without	
over	too much	
per	through	
pre	before	
re	again/back	remove
semi	half	
sub	under	
super	above/better/bigger	
trans	across	
tri	three	
un	not/opposite of	
under	too little	



9. Fill in the correct form of the words in brackets:

- 1 The toxic chemical use for cotton cultivation resulted to (*serious*) birth defects.
- 2 Polyester microfibres have (*ultimate*) become a serious threat to aquatic life.
- 3 How can you live near this factory? The smell is (*awful*) all around!
- 4 Fiber or fibre is a (*nature*) or synthetic substance that is (*significant*) longer than it is wide.
- 5 Organic cotton is (*general*) defined as cotton that is grown (*organical*) in (*subtropics*) countries such as Turkey, China, and parts of the USA from (*non-genetic*) modified plants, and without the use of any synthetic (*agriculture*) chemicals such as fertilizers or pesticides.

10. Dig deeper - Act wiser.



- a. Would you like to learn more? Visit the following links, read about the clothing issue and take notes about any new information. You may add your new knowledge in the last column of the KWL chart.

✓ WWF: "The Impact of a Cotton T-Shirt"

✓ The Economist: "The environmental costs of creating clothes"

<https://economist.com/the-economist-explains/2017/04/11/the-environmental-costs-of-creating-clothes?>

✓ The Guardian: "The problem with fast fashion – and how to fix it"

<https://www.theguardian.com/lifeandstyle/2014/aug/13/problem-with-fast-fashion-how-to-fix-it>

✓ The Guardian: "Rana Plaza a year on: did fast-fashion brands learn any lessons at all?"

<https://www.theguardian.com/world/2014/apr/20/rana-plaza-bangladesh-disaster-anniversary>

✓ The Guardian: "Shop less, mend more: making more sustainable fashion choices"

<https://www.theguardian.com/lifeandstyle/2018/feb/10/shop-less-mend-more-making-more-sustainable-fashion-choices>

✓ Wikipedia: "Sustainable fashion" https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sustainable_fashion

✓ Greenpeace: "A Gap between your Words and the Truth"

<https://wayback.archive-it.org/9650/20200303000153/http://p3-raw.greenpeace.org/international/en/news/Blogs/makingwaves/a-gap-between-your-words-and-the-truth/blog/44914/>

✓ Fair Trade <http://www.fairtrade.org.uk/>

✓ Hossain, M. S. (2015). Prospects and Constraints for Designing a Sustainable 'T-Shirt': A Life Cycle Analysis. Applied Ecology and Environmental Sciences, 3(2), 36-41. <http://pubs.sciepub.com/aees/3/2/2/index.html#>

b. "A talking image" to inform.

The life cycle of a T-shirt and its impact



Get inspired by the image. Select a stage/phase and find out how a beloved T-shirt can harm the environment during this stage. Spread the word and inform everyone around you.

Either:

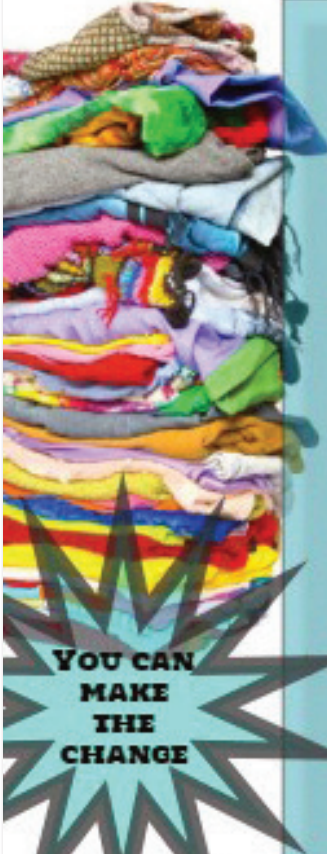
- ☐ Create a poster adding your findings next to the proper circle and post it on your school walls.
- ☐ Create an interactive image and share the link on your school's webpage/social page, your classroom's blog or even on your personal social page.

c. Would you like to take action? There are further instructions on the poster below:

Be a responsible and active citizen

Take action

A GREEN FASHION FAN?



- Learn about alternative, eco-friendly materials and shops selling such products in your area.
- Try mending or remaking.
- Create posters for your school walls to spread your new knowledge.
- Organise with your teacher a swap day at school and invite everyone to actively participate .
- Check if there are bins for recycling clothing in the nearby area.
- If there are no such bins, write a letter to the city council or an article for the local newspaper.
- Create a blog relevant to green fashion and keep it updated.

**YOU CAN
MAKE
THE
CHANGE**

You can create your own posters using a "poster creator" application on the internet.

